Northbridge Mobility - Work Visa Guide for International Hires (2026 edition)

1. About this guide and our service packages

This guide is the internal playbook of Northbridge Mobility, the immigration practice of consultant Ana Silva. It summarises how we plan work visas for international new hires. Government rules change often: always confirm current salary thresholds and fees on the official government website before filing.

Essential package - 450 EUR. Route assessment, personalised document checklist, review of the application before submission. Suitable for single applicants with a straightforward case.

Relocation package - 1,200 EUR. Everything in Essential plus appointment booking, translation management, family applications (spouse and children), and support until the residence card is issued.

Employer retainer - from 3,500 EUR per year. For companies hiring five or more international employees a year: sponsor licence or employer registration, hiring-pipeline planning and a dedicated case manager.

Our fees never include government fees, translations or courier costs. We refund 50 percent of the package fee if the client cancels before we start the document review, and nothing after the application has been filed.

2. Documents and lead times

Every route needs the same core set of documents. Start the slowest items on the first day.

Passport: valid for at least 12 months after the planned start date, with two blank pages.

Employment contract or binding job offer: must state job title, gross annual salary, working hours and start date. Unsigned drafts are not accepted by any consulate we work with.

Degree certificate and transcript: certified copies. Germany's EU Blue Card requires a degree that is recognised (check the anabin database, or request a statement of comparability from ZAB, which takes 2 to 12 weeks).

Apostille: civil and academic documents issued in Brazil, Mexico, India and other Hague Convention countries need an apostille. In Brazil, any notary office (cartorio) can issue it in 1 to 5 working days.

Police clearance certificate: issued less than 90 days before filing. The Brazilian Federal Police certificate is available online the same day; Indian police clearance typically takes 2 to 4 weeks.

Certified translations: needed when a document is not in English or the destination language; allow 1 to 2 weeks.

Health insurance: proof of cover from the first day of residence.

Typical longest pole: degree recognition (up to 12 weeks) followed by the consulate appointment wait.

3. Routes and typical timelines we observe

The timelines below are what our clients experienced in 2025-2026, measured from a complete document set to visa issuance. They are not official processing times.

Germany - EU Blue Card: for university graduates with a qualifying salary. With the employer's fast-track procedure (beschleunigtes Fachkraefteverfahren) the consulate appointment is usually offered within 3 weeks and the visa issued 2 to 4 weeks later. Without fast-track, appointment waits in Sao Paulo have been 4 to 10 weeks.

Netherlands - Highly skilled migrant: the employer must be a recognised sponsor. Decisions usually arrive in 2 to 4 weeks; the employee can then collect the entry visa (MVV) where required.

Portugal - Tech visa / highly qualified activity: attractive for start-ups certified under the Tech Visa programme; consulate processing has taken 6 to 12 weeks.

United Kingdom - Skilled Worker: needs a licensed sponsor and a Certificate of Sponsorship. Decisions outside the UK usually take about 3 weeks; priority services may be available for an extra fee.

Planning rule of thumb: for a Brazilian engineer joining a German employer, plan 8 to 12 weeks from signed contract to first working day with fast-track, and 12 to 16 weeks without it.

4. Families, pitfalls and when to refer

Family members: spouses and minor children can usually apply together with the main applicant. Marriage and birth certificates need an apostille and a certified translation. EU Blue Card family members in Germany do not need to prove language skills.

Common pitfalls: salary below the threshold after the annual update; job title that does not match the degree; expired police certificate; unsigned contract; booking flights before the visa is issued.

Start dates: always make the contract start date conditional on the work permit and allow a two-week buffer after the expected visa date.

When we refer to a lawyer: previous visa refusals, criminal records, overstays, asylum cases and appeals. These need a licensed immigration lawyer and are outside our packages.

Contact: book a call through the TopSkill agent page; we reply within one working day.